

Football-Connect — A Global, Multi-Role Web Platform Connecting Players, Academies, Agents, and Coaches

Semester 5 project proposal · Computer Software Engineering

INSTITUTION

Lincoln College of Science Management and
Technology

DEPARTMENT

Computer Software Engineering

STUDENT ID

LCSMT-NGA-005-ADM-1001393

STUDENT NAME

Olufemi Emmanuel Olugbodi

SEMESTER

Semester 5

SUPERVISOR

Mr Umar Shehu Abdulwahab

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1.1 Background

Every year, thousands of talented footballers go unseen — not because they lack ability, but because they lack a channel. A promising winger training with a small academy in Enugu has no formal way to reach an agent in Lagos, let alone a club scout in Europe. An academy with real coaching quality has no way to advertise a vacancy beyond word of mouth. A licensed agent trying to build a legitimate roster has to work through scattered WhatsApp groups and unverifiable claims, with no way to tell a real player profile from a fabricated one. This is not one academy's problem — it is a structural gap in how football talent, opportunity, and trust move across the game at grassroots and semi-professional level, especially outside the handful of markets with mature scouting infrastructure.

Football-Connect is a web platform built to close that gap. Rather than serving a single club or academy, it is designed as shared infrastructure for the wider football ecosystem: a place where a player can build a free, credible profile with video and CV evidence; where an academy or club can recruit coaches and be discovered by players; where a licensed agent can search, verify, and message talent directly; and where every interaction — a message, a training session, a job posting — happens inside one platform with real moderation and real security behind it, instead of across a dozen disconnected apps. The platform has been built and hardened through this development cycle and is fully functional in its current environment; this proposal sets out the platform as delivered so far and the features planned for the next development phase.

1.2 Project Overview

Football-Connect is a secure, responsive, multi-language web platform serving five distinct account types: **Player** (free, self-service), **Academy/Club**, **Agent/Scout**, **Coach/Manager**, and **Super Admin**. Each role gets a purpose-built profile, a shared inbox for direct messaging with any other user on the platform, a community feed that supports posts, photos, video, and live-linked online training sessions, a job board connecting clubs to coaches, and search tools for talent discovery. The entire interface is delivered in English, French, Portuguese, and Arabic — including full right-to-left layout support for Arabic — so the platform speaks to the regions where the talent gap is widest.

For the next development phase, the platform will be extended with AI-assisted player–club matching, a formal verified trial and scouting workflow, a native mobile application with push notifications, live streaming of training and trial sessions, a

structured player performance analytics dashboard, gamified trust and engagement badges, a sustainable subscription tier for professional accounts, and expanded language coverage. Together these additions move Football-Connect from a functional networking platform into a complete, self-sustaining talent pipeline.

02 Problem Statement

Across grassroots and semi-professional football, the same structural problems repeat regardless of country. Football-Connect was scoped around the following, specifically:

2.1 Fragmented Global Talent Pipeline

Outside a small number of well-scouted markets, talented players simply have no formal route to an academy, agent, or club. Discovery depends on luck, geography, and personal connections rather than merit, which means real ability is routinely missed.

2.2 Administrative Burden for Academies and Agents

Academies and agents manage recruitment through spreadsheets, phone contacts, and WhatsApp groups. There is no shared system for tracking who has been contacted, what stage a conversation is at, or which credentials have actually been checked.

2.3 Limited Player Visibility and Self-Promotion Tools

A player rarely has anywhere to put a CV, highlight video, club history, and achievements in one place that a stranger — an agent, a scout, a club — can credibly view. Without that, a player's only "profile" is whatever gets forwarded informally.

2.4 Agent and Scout Verification Gaps

Because recruitment happens off-platform, there is no way for a player or family to confirm that someone claiming to be a licensed agent actually is one, or which region and clubs they genuinely represent. This exposes players — many of them minors — to real risk.

2.5 Coaching Job Market Inefficiency

Coaching vacancies circulate informally and rarely reach the widest possible pool of qualified candidates. Academies default to whoever they already know, rather than whoever is best qualified.

2.6 Communication Silos

Recruitment conversations are scattered across phone calls, SMS, and multiple messaging apps with no shared record, no moderation, and no way for a platform operator to intervene if something goes wrong.

2.7 Language Barriers

Most recruitment tools assume English. That excludes large, football-rich populations across Francophone West and Central Africa, Lusophone Africa, and Arabic-speaking North Africa and the Gulf — precisely the regions with some of the deepest, least-scouted talent pools.

2.8 Trust and Safety Concerns

An open platform that connects players — some of them minors — directly with adults acting as agents, scouts, and coaches carries real safeguarding risk. Most existing tools have no moderation model, no account-suspension workflow, and no consent handling at all.

Football-Connect addresses each of the problems above directly. The platform is fully built and operating in its current development environment, with a further phase of features scoped below.

3.1 Core Platform (Already Developed)

3.1.1 Free, Self-Service Registration for Every Role

Academies, agents, coaches, and — critically — players can all register directly and start using the platform immediately, with no administrative approval bottleneck standing between sign-up and first use. Academies register with license number, country, address, phone, and a license document upload; agents with agency name, FIFA-style license reference, nationality, years of experience, and operating regions, plus an ID document upload; coaches with coaching badges, preferred role, experience, and nationality, plus a CV upload; players register free, with CV, highlight video, and photo uploads, club history, achievements, and a minor-consent flag for underage players. Removing the approval gate was a deliberate design decision: it is the single biggest lever for adoption in a platform whose entire value depends on having players on it from day one.

3.1.2 Role-Specific Public Profiles

Every account type has a public-facing profile page, visible even to signed-out visitors, so a link to a player or academy can be shared directly with a scout or sponsor. Profiles are automatically hidden from public and search views the moment an account is suspended or removed by an administrator, so a de-platformed account cannot continue to be discoverable.

3.1.3 Open Messaging Inbox

Any user can message any other user directly through a built-in inbox — a player can be reached by an agent, an academy can message a coach about a vacancy, without either party needing to exchange personal phone numbers or email addresses first.

3.1.4 Community Feed with Live Training Hosting

Every account type can post to a shared community feed — text updates, photos, uploaded video, or embedded YouTube clips — with likes, comments, and pinning. The feed's most distinctive capability: any user can host an online training session directly from a post, attaching a scheduled date and time and a join link, which renders feed-wide as a highlighted "Training Session" card with a one-click join

button, turning the feed into a live coaching channel rather than a static noticeboard.

3.1.5 Job Board

Academies and clubs post coaching vacancies; coaches apply directly through the platform, with applications tracked against each posting — replacing informal, word-of-mouth hiring with a searchable, shared listing.

3.1.6 Search and Discovery

Agents and academies can search and filter player profiles to identify talent that matches what they are looking for, rather than relying entirely on inbound contact.

3.1.7 Administrative Moderation Dashboard

Super Admins can suspend, restore, or permanently remove any account on the platform, moderate feed content, and oversee every registration. The moderation system carries built-in safeguards: an administrator cannot suspend or delete their own account, and the platform will not allow the last remaining Super Admin to be removed — protecting the platform from being accidentally locked out of its own control panel.

3.1.8 Security Hardening

Every page is served under a Content-Security-Policy with a fresh cryptographic nonce issued per request, so no inline script can execute without it — closing off a major class of cross-site scripting attack without resorting to a blanket unsafe-inline exception. This sits alongside a full security-header suite (HSTS, X-Frame-Options, X-Content-Type-Options), tiered rate limiting on login, registration, and messaging routes, bcrypt password hashing under a strong complexity policy, CSRF protection on every form, and HTTP-only session cookies.

3.1.9 Full Internationalisation

The complete interface — not just marketing copy — is translated across English, French, Portuguese, and Arabic, with automatic right-to-left mirroring for Arabic layouts, so the reading direction, not just the words, is correct for Arabic-speaking users.

3.1.10 Responsive, Theme-Aware Interface

A navy-and-gold visual identity built around real stadium photography, with a full light and dark mode, delivered on a responsive Bootstrap 5.3 layout that holds up from a phone screen to a desktop monitor.

3.2 New Features for the Next Development Phase

The following features are scoped for the next phase of Football-Connect's development:

3.2.1 AI-Assisted Player–Club Matching

How it works: A recommendation engine scores player profiles against an academy or agent's stated interests — position, age range, region, and recent activity — and surfaces a ranked shortlist instead of requiring a manual search every time. **Why it matters:** It surfaces relevant players to the people looking for them without either side having to do the searching, and it puts active, well-maintained profiles ahead of dormant ones, which rewards players who keep their profile current.

3.2.2 Verified Trial and Scouting Workflow

How it works: A formal request-accept-decline flow replaces today's informal direct-message approach to trials — an agent or academy sends a structured trial request with a proposed date, the player or guardian accepts or declines, and the outcome is recorded. **Why it matters:** It gives both sides a clear, auditable record of scouting activity instead of a conversation that can be denied or forgotten, and it is the natural foundation for reputation and trust signals later.

3.2.3 Native Mobile Application with Push Notifications

How it works: A React Native application mirrors the web platform's dashboard, messaging, feed, and job board, authenticating with the same account, and pushes notifications for new messages, job matches, and upcoming training sessions. **Why it matters:** Across the platform's target regions, mobile is the primary — often the only — way people access the internet; a push notification reaches a player far more reliably than an email they may check once a week.

3.2.4 Live Trial and Training Streaming

How it works: The existing online-training-session feature is extended to support a genuine live broadcast via YouTube Live, so a remote agent, scout, or family member can watch a training session or trial as it happens, with the recording archived on the post afterward. **Why it matters:** It lets an agent evaluate a player without travelling, and it lets a family in another city watch their child train — both currently impossible on the platform.

3.2.5 Player Performance Analytics Dashboard

How it works: Coaches enter structured ratings for players after sessions — technical, physical, and tactical metrics — which build into a visualised progress

chart over time, instead of the free-text profile the platform offers today. **Why it matters:** It turns a coach's verbal feedback into a durable, comparable record that a player can show an agent as evidence of development, not just a claim.

3.2.6 Gamification and Trust Badges

How it works: Profile-completion badges, activity streaks, and — most importantly — a "verified" badge for agents and academies whose license or registration documents have been checked by an administrator. **Why it matters:** It gives players and families a visible, at-a-glance trust signal, and it gives serious agents and academies a reason to complete verification rather than skip it.

3.2.7 Subscription Tier for Professional Accounts

How it works: Agents and academies can opt into a paid tier unlocking advanced search filters, priority placement in messaging, and boosted profile visibility, while player accounts remain free permanently. **Why it matters:** It gives the platform a sustainable revenue model without ever charging the players it exists to help — the same asymmetry that makes recruitment and job-search platforms viable elsewhere.

3.2.8 Expanded Language Coverage

How it works: Spanish and Swahili are added on top of the existing four-language translation architecture, which was built to scale to additional locales without structural change. **Why it matters:** It extends the platform's reach into Latin American and East African football markets using infrastructure that already exists — a genuinely low-cost, high-reach addition.

4.1 A Platform, Not a Single Academy's Website

Most football-related platforms are built for one organisation — a single club or academy showcasing itself to the outside world. Football-Connect inverts that: it is neutral, shared infrastructure connecting many academies, many agents, many coaches, and any number of independent players, none of whom needs to already have a relationship with the others to find each other.

4.2 Free, Frictionless Entry for the Player

The player — the person with the least resources and the most to gain — registers for free and is active immediately, with no approval queue standing between them and a public profile. Most comparable platforms either gate players behind an academy's own onboarding or treat them as a secondary audience to paying agents and clubs.

4.3 Live Training as a First-Class Feed Feature

Rather than treating "live training" as a separate module, Football-Connect builds it directly into the community feed that every user already sees, so a scheduled session surfaces alongside ordinary posts with the same visibility and reach — no separate app or calendar to check.

4.4 Real Internationalisation, Not a Translated Homepage

The full interface, not just the landing page, works in English, French, Portuguese, and Arabic, with genuine right-to-left layout support for Arabic. Reaching Francophone, Lusophone, and Arabic-speaking football markets in their own language, at this depth, is rare among recruitment platforms of any kind.

4.5 Security and Moderation Built In from the Start

A nonce-based Content-Security-Policy, tiered rate limiting, and an administrative moderation system with explicit safeguards against an admin locking themselves out are not retrofits — they are part of the platform as delivered. For a platform whose core function is connecting minors with adults claiming professional credentials, this is not optional polish; it is the foundation the trust model depends on.

4.6 One Login, the Whole Pipeline

Discovery, messaging, job posting, live training, and moderation all live under one account and one login, rather than being spread across a directory site, a messaging app, and a jobs board that don't talk to each other.

5.1 Comparison with Typical Recruitment and Directory Tools

Most existing football recruitment tools fall into one of two categories: a paid, agent-facing directory with no player self-service, or a single-club website with no cross-organisation discovery at all. Both are typically English-only, offer no live or video-based scouting, provide little to no built-in messaging, and disclose little about their security posture.

TYPICAL TOOLS VS. FOOTBALL-CONNECT

CAPABILITY	TYPICAL RECRUITMENT TOOL	FOOTBALL-CONNECT
Player access	Often paid, or gated behind a club	Free, self-service, active immediately
Roles served	Usually one or two	Five, each with a dedicated profile
Messaging	Off-platform (phone, WhatsApp)	Built-in inbox between any two users
Live sessions	Not offered	Feed-native training hosting
Languages	English only, typically	English, French, Portuguese, Arabic (RTL)
Moderation	Rarely disclosed or absent	Admin suspension/restore with safety guards
Security posture	Rarely disclosed	Nonce-based CSP, rate limiting, CSRF, bcrypt

5.2 Advantages by Stakeholder

Players

A free, credible profile with CV, video, and achievements; direct access to agents and academies; visibility into training sessions and job-adjacent opportunities without cost.

Academies and Clubs

A public presence that attracts players and coaches; a job board that reaches more candidates than word of mouth; direct messaging that replaces informal outreach.

Agents and Scouts

Searchable player profiles, direct messaging, and — in the next phase — a verified badge and structured trial workflow that builds real credibility with families.

Coaches

A job board built for coaching roles specifically, a public profile showing badges and role history, and direct access to academies hiring.

Platform Administrators

Full moderation control with guardrails that prevent the platform from ever being left without an

Non-English-Speaking Users

A platform that reads correctly — including right-to-left for Arabic — rather than a translated landing page

administrator, and visibility into every account and post.

in front of an English-only product.

06 Technology Stack

6.1 Current Platform

LAYER	TECHNOLOGY
Backend framework	Laravel 11 (PHP 8.2), Eloquent ORM
Database	MySQL 8
Templating / frontend	Blade, Bootstrap 5.3 (with RTL build for Arabic)
Asset build	Vite 6
Client-side scripting	Modular vanilla JavaScript, CSP-nonce-safe event delegation (no inline handlers)
Security	Custom SecurityHeaders middleware (per-request CSP nonces, HSTS, X-Frame-Options, X-Content-Type-Options), Laravel Auth, CSRF, RateLimiter
Internationalisation	Laravel translation engine (flat JSON locale files), laravel-lang/lang package
Testing	PHPUnit via Laravel's testing framework
Local environment	XAMPP (Apache + MySQL)

6.2 Planned Additions

FEATURE	TECHNOLOGY
AI-assisted matching & analytics	Python, FastAPI, scikit-learn
Mobile application	React Native (Android and iOS)
Push notifications	Firebase Cloud Messaging
Live streaming	YouTube Live API
Subscriptions / payments	Paystack / Flutterwave integration

07 Project Objectives

7.1 General Objective

To extend Football-Connect from a secure, multi-role networking platform into a complete talent pipeline that matches, verifies, and connects players with academies, agents, and coaches worldwide — safely, in their own language.

7.2 Specific Objectives

01 Build an AI-assisted matching engine recommending players to academies and agents.

Deliverable: Ranked shortlist view driven by a Python/FastAPI matching service.

02 Replace informal DM-based trial requests with a structured, auditable workflow.

Deliverable: Trial request, accept/decline, and outcome-recording system.

03 Ship a native mobile application mirroring the web platform.

Deliverable: React Native app on Android and iOS with push notifications.

04 Extend the feed's training-session feature to support genuine live broadcast.

Deliverable: YouTube Live integration with post-session archiving.

05 Introduce structured, coach-entered performance tracking for players.

Deliverable: Ratings input form and a visualised progress dashboard.

06 Add trust signals for verified professional accounts.

Deliverable: Admin-issued verification badges on agent and academy profiles.

07 Launch a paid tier for agents and academies without charging players.

Deliverable: Subscription billing via Paystack/Flutterwave with feature gating.

08 Extend language coverage beyond the current four locales.

Deliverable: Spanish and Swahili added to the existing translation architecture.

8.1 Wider, Fairer Talent Discovery

Players outside traditionally well-scouted markets gain a real, free channel to agents, academies, and coaches — discovery becomes a function of a maintained profile rather than proximity or luck.

8.2 Faster, More Accountable Recruitment

Matching and structured trial workflows replace ad-hoc spreadsheets and message threads, giving academies and agents a record of who was contacted, when, and with what outcome.

8.3 Stronger Trust and Safety

Verification badges, moderation with built-in administrative safeguards, and an auditable trial workflow give families a real basis for trusting who they are dealing with — directly addressing the safeguarding gap identified in Section 2.8.

8.4 Genuine Reach into Underserved Language Markets

Full right-to-left Arabic support and Francophone/Lusophone coverage — soon joined by Spanish and Swahili — put the platform in front of some of the least-scouted, most talent-dense regions in the world, in the language they actually use.

8.5 A Sustainable Platform

A subscription tier for agents and academies gives Football-Connect a path to funding its own continued operation without ever charging the players it exists to serve.

09 Project Timeline & Execution Plan

Each phase pairs one problem from Section 2 with the feature that solves it and the specific technology used to build it — so the roadmap below is also a direct record of how the selected stack executes the proposed solution.

EXECUTION MATRIX: PROBLEM → FEATURE → TECHNOLOGY → PHASE

PHASE	FEATURE	PROBLEM ADDRESSED	TECHNOLOGY	DURATION
1	Requirements & system design	Baseline for all Section 2 problems	API specs, ERD updates on the existing Laravel schema	2 wks
2	AI-assisted matching (O1) & trial workflow (O2)	2.1 Fragmented talent pipeline, 2.2 Administrative burden	Python + FastAPI microservice, scikit-learn, new Laravel trial-request tables	3 wks
3	Mobile application (O3)	2.6 Communication gaps, mobile-first access in target regions	React Native (Android & iOS), existing Laravel API endpoints	4 wks
4	Performance analytics dashboard (O5)	No equivalent in Section 2 — a forward-looking coach/player development gap identified after launch	Laravel-native ratings model, chart visualisation on the existing Blade/Bootstrap frontend	2 wks
5	Live streaming (O4), trust badges (O6), subscriptions (O7)	2.4 Agent/scout verification gaps, 2.5 Coaching job market inefficiency, platform sustainability	YouTube Live API, admin-issued badge flag on existing profile models, Paystack/Flutterwave billing integration	3 wks
6	Integration testing & user acceptance	Validates every phase above end-to-end	PHPUnit feature tests, manual cross-role acceptance testing	2 wks
7	Deployment & documentation, expanded languages (O8)	2.7 Language barriers	Production deployment, Spanish/Swahili added to the existing JSON translation architecture	2 wks

Total duration: 18 weeks (approximately 4.5 months).

9.1 Why This Order

Matching and the trial workflow come first because they extend data structures the platform already has (players, agents, academies) without depending on any other new feature — the fastest path to a visible improvement. The mobile app follows because it depends on stable API endpoints from Phase 2 rather than the reverse. Analytics, streaming, badges, and subscriptions are grouped toward the middle because they build on the platform's existing profile and feed models rather than introducing new external dependencies of their own. Testing is deliberately a

standalone phase rather than something squeezed into each feature phase, so every feature is verified working together — not just in isolation — before deployment.

10 Conclusion

Football-Connect already solves a problem most academy or agent tools never attempt: it gives every part of the football ecosystem — player, academy, agent, coach — a shared, secure, free-to-enter place to find each other, in their own language. The next development phase does not change that foundation; it makes the pipeline the platform enables more precise, more verifiable, and more sustainable — from AI-assisted matching and a formal trial workflow, through a native mobile app and live streaming, to trust badges and a funding model that never charges the player.

The technical approach builds directly on the platform's existing Laravel foundation and security posture rather than replacing it, and the phased timeline keeps each addition testable and reviewable on its own before the next begins. Delivered in full, this phase turns Football-Connect from a well-built networking platform into a genuine, self-sustaining talent pipeline — one built, deliberately, for the markets that need it most.

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Appendix A: System Architecture Diagram

Diagram of the platform architecture, covering the Laravel application, MySQL database, file storage, the security-headers middleware layer, and planned external integrations (matching microservice, push notifications, streaming, payments).

Appendix B: Database Schema

Entity-relationship diagram covering Users and their role profiles (Academy, Agent, Coach, Player), FeedPost, PostComment, and PostLike, Conversation and Message, and JobPost and JobApplication.

Appendix C: User Flow Diagrams

- Registration flow for each role
- Messaging flow between two users
- Feed posting and live training-session hosting flow
- Job posting and application flow
- Admin suspend / restore / remove flow

Appendix D: Sample Screenshots

- Homepage
- Registration forms (Academy, Agent, Coach, Player)
- Role dashboards
- Community Feed, including a live training-session post
- Admin moderation dashboard

Appendix E: Security Audit Checklist

- Content-Security-Policy nonce configuration
- Rate-limiting thresholds by route
- Password hashing and complexity policy
- Admin self-removal / last-admin safeguard verification

Appendix F: Deployment Configuration

- Environment variables
- Build pipeline (Vite asset compilation)
- Domain and hosting configuration

13 Declaration

I, Olufemi Emmanuel Olugbodi, hereby declare that this project proposal is my original work and all sources used have been duly acknowledged.

STUDENT SIGNATURE

DATE

Olufemi Emmanuel Olugbodi

Supervisor's Approval

I approve this project proposal and confirm that the student has met the requirements for Semester 5.

SUPERVISOR NAME

SUPERVISOR SIGNATURE

Mr Umar Shehu Abdulwahab